

HSK 2 Grammar & Syntax

Complete Pattern Reference

汉语水平考试二级·语法句型指南

HSK 3.0 Standard · Words 301–500

Pinyin · Examples · Usage Notes

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Pattern 1 · Comparison with 比 比

Structure: A 比 B + Adjective	Meaning: A is more [adjective] than B
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比 (bǐ) is the primary tool for making direct comparisons. The adjective follows immediately after the second noun — do NOT insert 更 (gèng) or 非常 between 比 and the adjective unless modifying further.

今天比昨天冷。

Jīntiān bǐ zuótiān lěng.

Today is colder than yesterday.

她比我高。

Tā bǐ wǒ gāo.

She is taller than me.

坐地铁比坐公交车快。

Zuò dìtiě bǐ zuò gōngjiāochē kuài.

Taking the subway is faster than taking the bus.

Degree adverbs after the adjective

You can quantify the gap: A 比 B + Adjective + 多了 / 一点儿 / 得多

他比我高多了。

Tā bǐ wǒ gāo duō le.

He is much taller than me.

这条路比那条路长一点儿。

Zhè tiáo lù bǐ nà tiáo lù cháng yìdiǎnr.

This road is a little longer than that one.

Negation

Structure: A 没有 B + Adjective	Meaning: A is not as [adjective] as B
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我没有她高。

Wǒ méiyǒu tā gāo.

I'm not as tall as her.

Common error: 他比我更高 — the 更 is redundant here. 更 is correct when saying 'even more' in a non-比 sentence: 他很高，我更高。

不如 (bùrú) is a more formal alternative meaning 'not as good as': 我的汉语不如她。(My Chinese is not as good as hers.)

Pattern 2 · The 是…的 Construction 是…的

Structure: 是 + [Time/Place/Manner] + Verb + 的	Meaning: Emphasizes when, where, or how a past action occurred
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Use 是…的 when the action itself is already known/established and you want to highlight a detail about it. The 是 can often be omitted in speech; 的 at the end is mandatory.

我是坐地铁来的。

Wǒ shì zuò dìtiě lái de.

I came by subway. (emphasis: how)

他是昨天到的。

Tā shì zuótiān dào de.

He arrived yesterday. (emphasis: when)

你是在哪儿学的中文？

Nǐ shì zài nǎr xué de Zhōngwén?

Where did you learn Chinese? (emphasis: where)

If the verb takes an object, 的 can appear before or after the object: 我是在北京学的中文 / 我是在北京学中文的 — both are correct.

Pattern 3 · Progressive Aspect: 正在 / 在…呢 正在 / 在…呢

Structure: 正在 / 在 + Verb (+ Object) + 呢

Meaning: Action is in progress right now

正在 (zhèngzài) and 在 both mark ongoing action. 正在 is stronger — it means 'right at this moment'. The sentence-final particle 呢 adds emphasis but is optional. Any of the three elements alone can mark the progressive.

他正在看书。

Tā zhèngzài kàn shū.

He is reading right now.

我们在吃饭呢。

Wǒmen zài chīfàn ne.

We're eating (right now).

她在跑步。

Tā zài pǎobù.

She is jogging.

正 (zhèng) alone can also mark progression: 她正睡觉。(She is sleeping.) This is slightly more literary.

Do NOT confuse 在 (progressive marker) with 在 (preposition of location). Context and position clarify: 他在图书馆 (He is at the library) vs. 他在看书 (He is reading).

Pattern 4 · Completed Action Marker: 了 (le) 了

Verbal 了: completion of an action

Structure: Verb + 了 + (Object)

Meaning: The action has been completed

我吃了早饭。

Wǒ chī le zǎofàn.

I ate breakfast.

他买了一本书。

Tā mǎi le yī běn shū.

He bought a book.

Sentence-final 了: change of state / new situation

Structure: Sentence + 了

Meaning: Something has changed; a new situation exists

天黑了。

Tiān hēi le.

It has gotten dark.

他会说中文了。

Tā huì shuō Zhōngwén le.

He can speak Chinese now. (he couldn't before)

Negation of completed actions

Structure: 没(有) + Verb

Meaning: Action did NOT happen (no 了)

我没吃早饭。

Wǒ méi chī zǎofàn.

I didn't eat breakfast.

When negating, drop 了 entirely — never say 没吃了. The 了 and 没 are in direct competition.

Specific quantity phrases require 了 after the verb but before the object: 他喝了三杯咖啡。(He drank three cups of coffee.)

Pattern 5 · Experienced Action Marker: 过 (guò) 过

Structure: Verb + 过 + (Object)

Meaning: Have ever done X; life experience

过 marks that an action occurred at some unspecified point in the past as part of one's life experience. Unlike 了, it carries no implication about the current state.

我去过中国。

Wǒ qù guò Zhōngguó.

I have been to China (at some point).

你吃过饺子吗？

Nǐ chī guò jiǎozi ma?

Have you ever eaten dumplings?

我没坐过高铁。

Wǒ méi zuò guò gāotiě.

I have never ridden a high-speed train.

Key distinction: 我去了中国 (I went to China — specific trip, focus on completion) vs. 我去过中国 (I have been to China — experience, no specific trip in mind).

过年 (guò nián) is a fixed compound meaning 'celebrate Chinese New Year' — the 过 here is the main verb, not the aspect marker.

Pattern 6 · Ongoing State Marker: 着 (zhe) 着

Structure: Verb + 着 + (Object)	Meaning: Maintaining a state or continuous background action
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着 differs from the progressive (正在): 正在 focuses on an action actively unfolding; 着 focuses on the resulting state being maintained. It often provides the background condition for another action.

门开着。

Mén kāi zhe.
The door is open. (state)

他坐着看书。

Tā zuò zhe kàn shū.
He reads while sitting down.

她笑着说：'你好！'

Tā xiào zhe shuō: 'Nǐ hǎo!'
She said 'hello' with a smile.

Pattern Verb₁ + 着 + Verb₂: the first verb describes the manner or posture in which the second verb is performed. Very common in natural speech.

Pattern 7 · Modal Verbs: 会 / 能 / 可以 / 要 / 想 能愿动词

Modal	Pinyin	Core Meaning	Key Use
会	huì	Learned ability; will (future)	skills acquired through learning
能	néng	Physical/situational ability	capacity, permission by circumstance
可以	kěyǐ	Permission; possibility	asking/granting permission
要	yào	Want to; need to; will	desire, necessity, future intention
想	xiǎng	Would like to; think	softer desire/intention

会 (huì) — learned ability / future

她会说三种语言。

Tā huì shuō sān zhǒng yǔyán.
She can speak three languages.

明天会下雨。

Míngtiān huì xià yǔ.
It will rain tomorrow.

能 (néng) — situational capacity

你能帮我吗？

Nǐ néng bāng wǒ ma?

Can you help me? (are you able to?)

我今天不能来。

Wǒ jīntiān bù néng lái.

I can't come today.

可以 (kěyǐ) — permission

这里可以拍照吗？

Zhèlǐ kěyǐ pāizhào ma?

Is it okay to take photos here?

你可以走了。

Nǐ kěyǐ zǒu le.

You may leave now.

要 (yào) vs. 想 (xiǎng)

我要去旅游。

Wǒ yào qù lǚyóu.

I'm going to travel. (firm intention)

我想去旅游。

Wǒ xiǎng qù lǚyóu.

I'd like to travel. (softer wish)

Negation differences: 不会 (can't/won't), 不能 (unable/not allowed situationally), 不可以 (not permitted), 不要 = 别 (don't!), 不想 (don't feel like).

Pattern 8 · Resultative Complements with 得 (de) 程度补语

Structure: Verb + 得 + Adjective/Predicate

Meaning: Describes how well / to what degree the action is done

得 (de — complement particle, different from 的 and 地) links a verb to a predicate describing the result or degree of that action.

她说得很好。

Tā shuō de hěn hǎo.

She speaks very well.

他跑得很快。

Tā pǎo de hěn kuài.

He runs very fast.

你写得不错。

Nǐ xiě de búcuò.

You write quite well.

With an object

When the verb takes an object, repeat the verb after the object: V + Object + V + 得 + Complement

他汉字写得很漂亮。

Tā Hànzì xiě de hěn piàoliang.

He writes Chinese characters beautifully.

Negation

Structure: Verb + 得 / 不 + Complement	Meaning: Potential: can/cannot achieve the result
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我听得懂。 / 我听不懂。

Wǒ tīng de dǒng. / Wǒ tīng bu dǒng.

I can understand it. / I can't understand it.

The three 'de' particles — 的 (possessive/attributive modifier), 地 (adverbial), 得 (complement) — have the same pronunciation but different functions and characters.

Pattern 9 · Directional Complements 趋向补语

Directional complements attach to a verb to show the direction of movement relative to the speaker. Simple ones use 来 (toward speaker) or 去 (away from speaker). Compound ones combine a directional verb with 来/去.

上来	shànglái	come up
上去	shàngqù	go up
下来	xiàlái	come down
下去	xiàqù	go down
进来	jìnlái	come in
进去	jìnqù	go in
出来	chūlái	come out
出去	chūqù	go out
回来	huílái	come back
回去	huíqù	go back
过来	guòlái	come over

过去	guòqù	go over / pass by
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快进来！

Kuài jìn lái!

Come in quickly!

他从楼上走下来了。

Tā cóng lóushàng zǒu xià lái le.

He walked down from upstairs.

请拿出护照来。

Qǐng ná chū hùzhào lái.

Please take out your passport.

When the verb takes an object, the object usually goes between the directional verb and 来/去: 拿出护照来 (not 拿出来护照).

Pattern 10 · 因为…所以 (Because…Therefore) 因为…所以

Structure: 因为 + Cause, 所以 + Result	Meaning: Expresses cause and effect
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Both clauses can stand alone or together. In natural speech, one is often omitted. 所以 (suǒyǐ) cannot open a sentence in formal writing if 因为 is absent — but this rule relaxes in colloquial usage.

因为下雨，所以我没出门。

Yīnwèi xià yǔ, suǒyǐ wǒ méi chūmén.

Because it rained, I didn't go out.

因为我很累，所以早睡了。

Yīnwèi wǒ hěn lèi, suǒyǐ zǎo shuì le.

Because I was tired, I went to bed early.

You can use 因为 alone (just giving reason) or 所以 alone (just giving consequence). Using both together is more complete and formal.

Do NOT use 因为 and 因此 together — 因此 is a more formal single-word connector and replaces the entire 因为…所以 pattern.

Pattern 11 · 虽然…但是 (Although…But) 虽然…但是

Structure: 虽然 + Concession, 但是 + Contrast	Meaning: Acknowledges one fact, then introduces a contrasting fact
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虽然他很忙，但是还是来了。

Suīrán tā hěn máng, dànshì háishì lái le.

Although he was busy, he still came.

虽然天气冷，但是我喜欢冬天。

Suīrán tiānqì lěng, dànshì wǒ xǐhuan dōngtiān.

Although the weather is cold, I like winter.

但 (dàn) is the shorter, slightly more literary form of 但是. Both are HSK 2 words. 可是 (kěshì) is an HSK 3 colloquial equivalent.

Unlike English, the subject usually stays outside 虽然 when it applies to both clauses: 他虽然很忙，但是还是来了 (subject first, then 虽然).

Pattern 12 · 还是 (háishi): Or / Still 还是

As a conjunction — 'or' (in questions)

Structure: A 还是 B?

Meaning: Presents two options; expects a choice

你喝咖啡还是喝茶？

Nǐ hē kāfēi hái shì hē chá?

Do you drink coffee or tea?

你坐地铁还是打车？

Nǐ zuò dìtiě hái shì dǎchē?

Are you taking the subway or a taxi?

As an adverb — 'still'

Structure: 还是 + Verb/Adj

Meaning: Something continues to be the case

他还是不懂。

Tā hái shì bù dǒng.

He still doesn't understand.

还是 questions are alternative questions — they present a closed set of options. Use 或者 (huòzhě, HSK 3) for 'or' in statements, not questions: 你可以坐地铁或者打车。(You can take the subway or a taxi.)

Pattern 13 · 就 (jiù): Then / Right Away / Exactly 就

Immediate/quick sequence: 'then', 'right away'

他一回来就睡觉了。

Tā yī huí lái jiù shuìjiào le.

As soon as he got back, he went to sleep.

我吃完饭就走。

Wǒ chī wán fàn jiù zǒu.

I'll leave right after eating.

Emphasis / certainty: 'exactly', 'precisely'

就是这个！

Jiùshì zhège!

It's exactly this one!

我就住在车站旁边。

Wǒ jiù zhù zài chēzhàn pángbiān.

I live right next to the station.

就 encodes the speaker's expectation that something happened sooner/faster than expected. Contrast with 才 (cái, HSK 3), which implies something happened later than expected: 他八点才来 (He didn't come until 8).
他八点就来了 (He came at 8 — early!).

Pattern 14 · Negative Imperative: 别 (bié) 别

Structure: 别 + Verb	Meaning: Don't do X
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别 is the standard spoken form for negative commands. 不要 (búyào) carries the same meaning and is slightly more emphatic or written.

别忘了！

Bié wàng le!

Don't forget!

别动！

Bié dòng!

Don't move!

别走，等一下。

Bié zǒu, děng yíxià.

Don't go, wait a moment.

别 and 不要 both work, but 别 is warmer and more natural in speech. 不 alone negates statements; 别/不要 negate commands.

Pattern 15 · 让 (ràng): Let / Allow / Cause 让

Structure: 让 + Person + Verb	Meaning: Cause/allow/make someone do something
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老师让我们准备考试。

Lǎoshī ràng wǒmen zhǔnbèi kǎoshì.

The teacher had us prepare for the exam.

妈妈不让我出去。

Māma bù ràng wǒ chūqù.

Mom won't let me go out.

让我想一想。

Ràng wǒ xiǎng yì xiǎng.

Let me think about it.

让 can also be used in passive-like constructions: 我让他等了一个小时 (I made him wait an hour) — or as a passive marker at HSK 3+: 书让他拿走了 (The book was taken away by him).

Pattern 16 · 快要…了 (About To) 快要…了

Structure: 快要 / 快 / 就要 + Verb + 了

Meaning: Something is about to happen imminently

飞机快要起飞了。

Fēijī kuàiyào qǐfēi le.

The plane is about to take off.

他快回来了。

Tā kuài huí lái le.

He'll be back soon.

考试就要开始了。

Kǎoshì jiùyào kāishǐ le.

The exam is about to start.

快要 and 快 can be used with a time phrase (下午、明天) but 就要 requires one: 他明天就要走了 / 他明天快要走了 / 他就要走了 (no time phrase, just urgency).

Pattern 17 · 已经…了 (Already) 已经…了

Structure: 已经 + Verb/Adj + 了

Meaning: Something has already happened or a state has already been reached

他已经走了。

Tā yǐjīng zǒu le.

He has already left.

我已经吃了早饭了。

Wǒ yǐjīng chī le zǎofàn le.

I've already eaten breakfast.

天气已经暖和了。

Tiānqì yǐjīng nuǎnhuo le.

The weather has already gotten warm.

The double 了 (verbal 了 + sentence-final 了) in the second example is acceptable and emphasises both completion and changed state. This is natural spoken Chinese.

Pattern 18 · 从…到 (From…To) 从…到

Structure: 从 + Start + 到 + End

Meaning: Covers span of time, place, or quantity

从北京到上海要多长时间？

Cóng Běijīng dào Shànghǎi yào duō cháng shíjiān?

How long does it take from Beijing to Shanghai?

他从早到晚都在学习。

Tā cóng zǎo dào wǎn dōu zài xuéxí.

He studies from morning to night.

从车站到学校要走二十分钟。

Cóng chēzhàn dào xuéxiào yào zǒu èrshí fēnzhōng.

It takes 20 minutes to walk from the station to school.

从小 (cóngxiǎo) is a fixed adverbial meaning 'from childhood/since young'.

Pattern 19 · 往 (wǎng): Towards 往

Structure: 往 + Direction / Place + Verb

Meaning: Movement or orientation towards a point

往前走，看到红绿灯右转。

Wǎng qián zǒu, kàndào hónglǜdēng yòu zhuǎn.

Go straight ahead, turn right at the traffic light.

往左看。

Wǎng zuǒ kàn.

Look to the left.

往 focuses on the direction of an action. Compare with 去 (qù, destination) and 朝/向 (cháo/xiàng, also 'toward' — more common in written/formal Chinese).

Pattern 20 · 每 (měi): Every 每

Structure: 每 + Measure Word + Noun / Time Word

Meaning: Refers to each unit of a set

我每天早上五点学习中文。

Wǒ měi tiān zǎoshang wǔ diǎn xuéxí Zhōngwén.

I study Chinese every day at 5 AM.

他每周去一次健身房。

Tā měi zhōu qù yī cì jiànshēnfáng.

He goes to the gym once every week.

每个人都有问题。

Měi gè rén dōu yǒu wèntí.

Every person has problems.

每 almost always co-occurs with 都 in the second clause to reinforce universality: 每个学生都要准备 (Every student must prepare). Omitting 都 is technically acceptable but sounds incomplete.

Pattern 21 · 一起 (yìqǐ): Together 一起

Structure: (和/跟 + Person +) 一起 + Verb

Meaning: Doing something together

我们一起去吃饭吧！

Wǒmen yìqǐ qù chīfàn ba!

Let's go eat together!

她跟朋友一起旅游。

Tā gēn péngyou yìqǐ lǚyóu.

She traveled together with her friends.

和 (hé) and 跟 (gēn) both mean 'with/and' when used with 一起. 跟 is more colloquial; 和 is slightly more neutral/written. Neither is wrong at HSK 2 level.

Pattern 22 · Adverbial Particle 地 (de) 地

Structure: Adjective / Adverb + 地 + Verb

Meaning: Adjective modifies the verb (how the action is done)

地 converts an adjective or reduplicated adjective into an adverb modifying the following verb. Think of it as '-ly' in English.

她高兴地笑了。

Tā gāoxìng de xiào le.

She laughed happily.

请慢慢地说。

Qǐng màn màn de shuō.

Please speak slowly.

他认真地准备考试。

Tā rènzhēn de zhǔnbèi kǎoshì.

He prepared for the exam seriously.

Reduplication (慢慢地, 好好地, 快地) is extremely common with 地 and adds emphasis. Single-syllable adjectives usually reduplicate before 地; two-syllable adjectives generally do not.

Pattern 23 · Topic-Comment Sentence Structure 主题-说明结构

Chinese is fundamentally a topic-prominent language. The topic (what the sentence is about) comes first, followed by the comment (what is said about it). This differs from English subject-verb-object order.

Structure: Topic, Comment

Meaning: Establish the topic; make a statement about it

这本书，我已经看完了。

Zhè běn shū, wǒ yǐjīng kàn wán le.

This book — I've already finished reading it.

中文语法，我觉得很有意思。

Zhōngwén yǔfǎ, wǒ juéde hěn yǒuyìsi.

Chinese grammar — I find it very interesting.

The topic is often the object of the comment's verb, fronted for emphasis or contrast. A comma or pause separates topic from comment in natural speech.

Pattern 24 · Serial Verb Constructions 连动句

Structure: Subject + Verb₁ + (Object₁) + Verb₂ + (Object₂)

Meaning: Two or more verbs in sequence with one subject

Chinese strings verbs together without conjunctions. The first verb often expresses method, direction, or purpose; the second expresses the main action or result.

我坐地铁去上班。

Wǒ zuò dìtiě qù shàngbān.

I take the subway to work.

他骑自行车去买东西。

Tā qí zìxíngchē qù mǎi dōngxi.

He rides his bike to go shopping.

请进来坐一坐。

Qǐng jìn lái zuò yī zuò.

Please come in and have a seat.

The verb reduplication pattern V + 一 + V (坐一坐, 看一看, 试一试) suggests doing something briefly or casually. Very common in invitations and suggestions.

Pattern 25 · Duration of Time Expressions 时量补语

Duration expressions come after the verb (and after the object if there is one). They tell you how long an action lasted.

Structure: Verb + Duration

Meaning: No object present

我学了两年中文。

Wǒ xué le liǎng nián Zhōngwén.

I studied Chinese for two years.

他睡了八个小时。

Tā shuì le bā gè xiǎoshí.

He slept for eight hours.

Structure: Verb + Object + Verb + Duration

Meaning: Object present: repeat the verb

他学汉语学了三年了。

Tā xué Hànyǔ xué le sān nián le.

He has been studying Chinese for three years.

For activities without a clear endpoint, use 了 after the duration to signal the action is still ongoing: 我学中文了一年了 (I've been studying Chinese for a year [and still am]).

Frequency (次, 遍) vs. duration: 我去了三次 (I went three times — frequency) vs. 我去了三天 (I was there for three days — duration).

Quick Reference Summary

比	A 比 B + Adj	A is more adj than B; use 没有 to negate
是…的	是 + context + V + 的	Emphasises when/where/how; action already known
正在…呢	正在 / 在 + V + 呢	Action in progress right now
了	V + 了 / Sentence + 了	Completion / change of state; negate with 没
过	V + 过	Life experience; ever done X
着	V + 着	Maintained state; background manner
会/能/可以	Modal + V	会=learned, 能=capacity, 可以=permission
得	V + 得 + Adj	Degree/result complement; repeat V if object present
趋向补语	V + 来/去, V + 上来…	Direction of movement relative to speaker
因为…所以	因为 + cause, 所以 + result	Causal; either clause can stand alone
虽然…但是	虽然 + concession, 但是 + contrast	Subject before 虽然 when shared
还是	A 还是 B? / 还是 + V	Alternative question / "still"
就	…就 + V	Immediate sequence / emphasis; contrast with 才
别	别 + V	Don't (imperative); = 不要
让	让 + person + V	Let/make someone do; can negate: 不让
快要…了	快要/就要 + V + 了	Imminent action; 就要 needs time phrase
已经…了	已经 + V + 了	Already; double 了 acceptable
从…到	从 + start + 到 + end	Span of time, place, or quantity
往	往 + direction + V	Movement towards; directions: 左右前后上下
每	每 + MW + N	Every; co-occurs with 都
一起	(跟/和 + sb.) 一起 + V	Together with someone
地	Adj + 地 + V	Adverb particle; adj modifies verb

主题-说明	Topic, Comment	Topic first; comment about it
连动句	S + V ₁ + V ₂	Serial verbs; V + 一 + V = briefly
时量补语	V + Duration / V+O+V+Duration	How long; 了 = still ongoing